



women performed in private theater troupes during the Ming Dynasty (1368–1644), the status of actresses in imperial China was as low as that of prostitutes. Women became more visible as performers in Shanghai only in the 1850s, when theaters began to hire all-female groups, such as the *maoer xi* (Maoer opera troupe).

New roles

Since the 20th century, women have had more opportunities to write and produce their own plays. From the 1970s onward, women have also worked together in collectives and all-female companies. Women have joined forces to stage feminist works and plays that focus on the female experience. One of the most notable feminist works was Eve Ensler's *The Vagina Monologues*, first performed in 1996, which she based on interviews with 200 women. Despite such initiatives, however, women today remain outnumbered two to one by men in most production and acting roles in Western theater—while making up the majority in its audiences.

▲ Black voices

American feminist writer Ntozake Shange stars in her 1977 play, *For Colored Girls Who Have Considered Suicide/When the Rainbow Is Enuf*. The piece is made up of seven monologues by African American women, and emphasizes realistic speech patterns.

PROFILES

STARS OF THE STAGE

Hroswitha (935–1000) was a nun who spent most of her life in the Benedictine convent at Gandersheim, Lower Saxony. She wrote six comedies in Latin based on the works of Roman writer Terence. The rediscovery of her manuscripts around 1500 led to her recognition.

Peg Woffington (1714–1760) was an Irish actress who rose to fame at the age of ten in John Gay's *The Beggar's Opera* in Dublin. John Rich employed her at a salary of five guineas a week when she played Silvia in *The Recruiting Officer* at Covent Garden theater in 1740, a role requiring her to appear in both petticoats and breeches. By 1745, she was earning an impressive £10 a week.

Sarah Bernhardt (1844–1923) was a French actress who became the first celebrity of her profession, performing in some of the most popular French plays of the 19th century. She was one of the first actresses to move from stage to screen, starring in silent films such as *Camille* (1911) and *The Loves of Queen Elizabeth* (1912).

Swanakumari Devi (1855–1932) was the first woman to write an Indian English drama. She was from the illustrious literary Tagore family of Bengal. Her play *The Wedding Tangle* (1904) deals with widowhood and remarriage. She also wrote novels, poems, essays, and even the first opera in Bengali, which addressed the position of women in Indian society.

Lorraine Hansberry (1930–1965) was the first African American woman to have a play produced on Broadway. Her play *A Raisin in the Sun* (1959) dealt with a family of black Americans living under racial segregation in Chicago. It was inspired by her own experience growing up on the South Side of Chicago.

Usha Ganguly (b. 1945) is an Indian director who founded the Rangakarmee theater group in 1976. She began directing in the 1980s, sparking a resurgence in Hindi theater with works such as *Mahabhoj* (1984). Her play about discrimination against girls, *Beti Aayee*, was first performed with an all-female cast in 1996.